

A letter you can keep

Dear Victory,

If I were there today, I would probably pretend I had planned exactly what to say. Then I would see you and forget half of it. I would make a bad joke, wait for that look you give me, and finally tell you this properly: happy birthday, amarachiii.

I still remember our first call. I cannot repeat every word, but I remember the nerves going away and how neither of us seemed ready to hang up. I remember the video calls, the voice notes, and the little goodnights that never felt little to me.

Being in Nigeria while you are in Russia has taught me that four hours can feel longer than four hours. I wish I could be beside you today, without a screen or a network deciding when I get to hear your voice. Until then, I hope these words reach you in the way I mean them.

I am proud of you. Twenty does not ask you to have everything figured out. You have already made it through changes and difficult chapters, and you are still finding your way toward the life you want. I hope this year gives you good news, rest when you need it, and more reasons to laugh out loud.

There is no need to answer this letter. Keep it for a day when you want to remember that someone far away was thinking of you, cheering you on, and grateful to have met you.

Happy twentieth birthday, Victory.

Favour